Agreements between the Sri Lankan government and the LTTE broke down over questions of amnesty and the ceasefire and spiralled into conflict involving the IPKF. An operation launched by India in October 1987 to take control of the town of Jaffna proved disastrous, with Indian forces suffering seventy fatalities. [45] The Indian military presence on the island grew larger over the following years, but the effort suffered from several shortcomings. One, as India learned early on, it consistently underestimated the LTTE as a fighting force. Two, India suffered from the ambivalence and later hostility of the Sri Lankan government, on whose behalf it was supposedly fighting the counterinsurgency. Sri Lankan President J.R. Jayewardene initially used the Indian presence to deal more forcefully with a separate insurgency in the south, but his successor Ranasinghe Premadasa reached a clandestine understanding with the LTTE and even provided them arms in a bid to rid his country of the Indian military presence. Three, the Sri Lanka war was unpopular in India, and became an issue in the 1989 General Elections. By 1990, the IPKF had lost over 1000 soldiers. With its intervention opposed by all parties, an inability to realize a political outcome, and a new government in New Delhi, Indian forces withdrew. [46] But the war followed them home. In 1991, Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated by an LTTE suicide bomber while on the campaign trail for the General Elections. [47] Despite the disaster of the IPKF intervention, Sri Lanka did not splinter, the LTTE was eventually defeated two decades later, New Delhi patched up relations with Colombo, and India managed to minimize external involvement. Nevertheless, the IPKF saga ended two decades of Indian interventionism in its region.

India’s interventionism did have some positive outcomes form India’s standpoint. India’s relations held relatively steady with Bhutan (with whom a 1949 Friendship Treaty endured), Bangladesh became independent under Mujibur Rehman, and Sikkim became a part of India. By the early 1990s, Nepal democratized and acknowledged Indian security concerns. Even in Sri Lanka, the possibility of a Tamil *eelam* was forestalled, despite the operational disasters of the IPKF intervention. Indian intervention also dampened the influence of outside powers in its immediate periphery. This